Data & Data Collection

Data Collection & Methods

The data for this paper is drawn from the USC Visual History Archive (VHA) which holds roughly 61,000 recorded interviews with survivors and witnesses of the Holocaust. Existing quantitative work on post-war Jewish migration is limited. The closest methodological precedent, Buggle et al. (2023), builds its dataset from records held by the German Federal Archives. Access to those records is restricted, so I could not replicate that design for the post-war period. The VHA offered a workable alternative. Its testimonies are transcribed and searchable, and the Claremont Colleges provide institutional access. My earlier research on displaced persons in the Czech Republic after the war also familiarized me with the archive's structure.

Out of the 60,000 testimonies, I filtered for three factors. First, I narrowed down to only testimonies from the Holocaust, second I refined my search for only testimonies in English, and lastly, I had to search for testimonies with transcripts. That left me with around 6,000 eligible testimonies. From this pool, I manually collected [101] testimonies (I plan to do more), selected by copy and pasting each transcript from the VHA into R Studio. I saved each transcript as a separate plain text file, one per survivor.

I extracted structured variables from the transcritp in R using regular expressions. The variables are the survivor's destination country (the first country outside Europe the survivor describes moving to after the war), mentions of immigration policy mechanisms (visas, quotas, affidavits) and air organizations (HIAS, the JDC, the IRO), and counts of threat and decision making language normalized per 1,000 words. I developed the keyword dictionaries iterativley. For a validation subset, I read each match in context and revised the patterns where they captured wartime events rather than post-war ones. For example, my first destination rule often picked up wartime flight and hiding locations, so the final version searches only the test that follows liberation. I then merged the extracted variables with VHA metadata, including birth year, birthplace and interview date. I plan to take a random sample of 20 testimonies and read them over to see where they went after the war and match those with what my code produced. I will then have a sentence that writes the extracted destination matched my reading in Y percent of cases and the departure year in Z percent of cases.

The dataset has several limitation. Selection bias is the most important. Every person in the archive chose to testify, so the sample over-represents survivors who lived to be interviewed (usually these interviews took place in the 1990s). Restricting to English-language testimonies with transcripts further over-represents survivors who emigrated to English-speaking countries, particularly the United States, and under-represents those who moved to Israel, Latin America, or elsewhere and gave testimony in other languages. The variables r also draft from self-reported accounts given decades after the events described, sl memory of dates and the sequence of moves in imperfect, and the regular-expression extraction adds measurement error of its own. I therefore will interpret the results as describing the experiences of VHA testimony-givers rather than all survivors.

The testimonies were accessed under the VHA's terms of use for institutional users. Names were removed from the dataset before analysis, and the transcripts themselves are not shared. The extraction code is available at https://github.com/chloedenhart/Data-Science-Capstone.